Bellwether · Year & Election

Setup

One firm per human. Reveal Support and policies before agent setup. Place complete firm groups in order 1–6. All firm cards start in hand; Hecate rewards start in supply. Firm kits never double.

Start each year

1. **Resurgence:** identify all parties with no board Support; keep that list fixed. Once clockwise from Early Bird, each player places one Support of each listed party, in their chosen order, into any free district capacity slots. No agent or region restriction; skip if full. One placement per party per human at all player counts.
2. **Party Openings:** Fiddler first, then clockwise from Early Bird, skipping Fiddler. Without Fiddler, start at Early Bird. At 2–3 players reverse order for a second round.
3. **Fiddler's burst:** spend or discard all favours.
4. **Lobby:** turns clockwise from Early Bird.

End the year

1. When more than half the opening markers are returned at turn end, Lobby ends.
2. Close remaining parties in firm order 1–6. At 2–3 players each owner chooses their two Closures' order. Resolve effects.
3. After Years 2, 4 and 6, hold the Election.
4. Refresh counters and markers; ending player becomes Early Bird. Prepare next year.
5. Release New Year cards into hands; agents stay. Begin next year with resurgence, then openings. No resurgence after Year 6.

Election

Outside Centre, randomly retain up to half district capacity: 1/2/3 Support for capacity 2/4/6. Centre keeps all. Surviving Support votes in its region. For > Against passes; ties fail.

Count all regions before activating laws. Award passed party policies to the largest surviving For contributor; ties use the leftmost tied party in the For row. Resolve Election prophecies before New Year release.

After Elections 1/2 reveal new policies. After Election 3 reveal priorities, score every enacted policy, apply global scoring laws, and release New Year before hand ranking.

Hand rank: one point per other player with no more common + party cards than you. Exclude firm/reward cards. Highest total wins; ties share.

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Choose one Lobby action

Operate: play 1–3 cards sequentially. Resolve each fully before choosing the next. Each card may use a different open acting party; party is fixed within a card. Firm cards need no acting party.

Collect: spend a Collection counter; take any open party's pile plus one available party card into New Year. Party stays open.

Close: after your first turn, take a party bearing your marker: pile plus one available party card → New Year; return marker. A party card is compulsory if available, even with an empty pile.

Pass: only when all your opening markers have returned. No deadlock exception.

Common Operations

Organise: agent at source containing acting-party Support. Move one Support to a free neighbouring space. Your movable agents at source may voluntarily accompany it.

Rally: agent at placement district containing acting-party Support. Add one Support if space.

Smear: agent at attacking district containing acting-party Support. Remove rival Support there or in a neighbour.

Absent party: if no acting-party Support exists, Organise/Rally places Support at the agent's district with space; Smear removes a rival there. Recovery Organise transports no agents.

Cards & agents

Common cards → acting-party pile. Party cards bypass agent locations and return home after play. Firm cards → New Year unless placed. Hecate reward cards → reward supply. Follow firm exceptions.

Agents use no Support capacity. Only Organise carries agents; portraits, puppeteer and marionettes never ride. Laws need no extra agents at their additional effects. All shared counts and placed state remain public; exact hands are private.

Portrait adjacency: awake portraits link their districts for all effects. Other players pay the Gallery one common/party card from hand before use; once per played card, separately for standalone effects.

First turn: no Close. Personal cards use Operate slots. Check year end only after the whole turn.